

UKRAINE RETURNS REPORT

GENERAL POPULATION SURVEY

ROUND 20
APRIL 2025



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OVERVIEW

Since the full-scale invasion of Ukraine by the Armed Forces of the Russian Federation in February 2022, the International Organization for Migration (IOM) has been collecting data on internally displaced persons (IDPs), returnees, and the non-displaced population through a nationwide representative General Population Survey (GPS). The purpose of the assessment is to provide an in-depth, granular understanding of displacement figures and mobility trends, as well as to gather fundamental data on the profiles, needs and intentions of

the displaced population in support of humanitarian efforts to find durable solutions to internal displacement. The GPS, implemented on a quarterly basis, also provides key analysis of trends over time. To this end, the GPS conducts oblast-level, randomised interviews with a representative sample of each population group. This report presents the findings of Round 20 of the GPS, which took place from 5 February to 4 April 2025.

KEY FINDINGS



There are an estimated 4,137,000 returnees in Ukraine. The main oblasts of return were Kyiv City, where 23% of returnees resided, Kharkivska (15%) and Kyivska (14%) Oblasts.



Close to half of all returnees (48%) had returned from displacement in another oblast in Ukraine, while 26 per cent had returned to their places of residence directly from abroad.



More than one-third of returnees (37%; 1,549,000 individuals) have returned to frontline raions. These returns primarily took place from oblasts which themselves are close to, or contain, frontline areas: Kharkivska (16%), Dnipropetrovska (12%), Poltavska (9%), Mykolaivska (7%), and Chernihivska (5%) Oblasts. Returns to frontline areas have consistently accounted for approximately 40 per cent of all returns over the past 9 to 11 months.



New returns continue to be recorded, with nine per cent of returnees reporting that they had returned three months prior to data collection. However, more than half of all returnees (52%) had returned over two years prior to data collection, and 77 per cent had returned over a year prior to data collection.



Comparable to previous rounds of data collection, seven per cent of returnees (280,000 individuals) were considering re-displacement in the three months following data collection, out of whom one-third (31%) intended to move to another country.



Those planning to leave reported lower levels of access to goods and services – 90 per cent of returnees considering leaving in the three months following data collection reported access gaps, compared to 74 per cent of returnees not considering leaving – and higher levels of reliance on coping strategies to meet needs – 92 per cent of returnees considering leaving reported that their households had relied on coping strategies, compared to 76 per cent of returnees who were not planning to leave. These findings suggest that challenges meeting needs contribute to unsustainable returns.



The majority (53%) of those surveyed crossing back into Ukraine were doing so for short-term visits (one month or less). Only two per cent of returnees crossing back from abroad expressed an intention to stay (more than a month).



Overall, returnees reported levels of access to goods and services similar to those of the non-displaced, with 75 per cent of returnees reporting insufficient access to at least one good or service, compared to 73 per cent of the non-displaced. Among both population groups, the highest levels of access gaps were reported in frontline areas, where 80 per cent of returnees and 79 per cent of the non-displaced reported at least one gap.

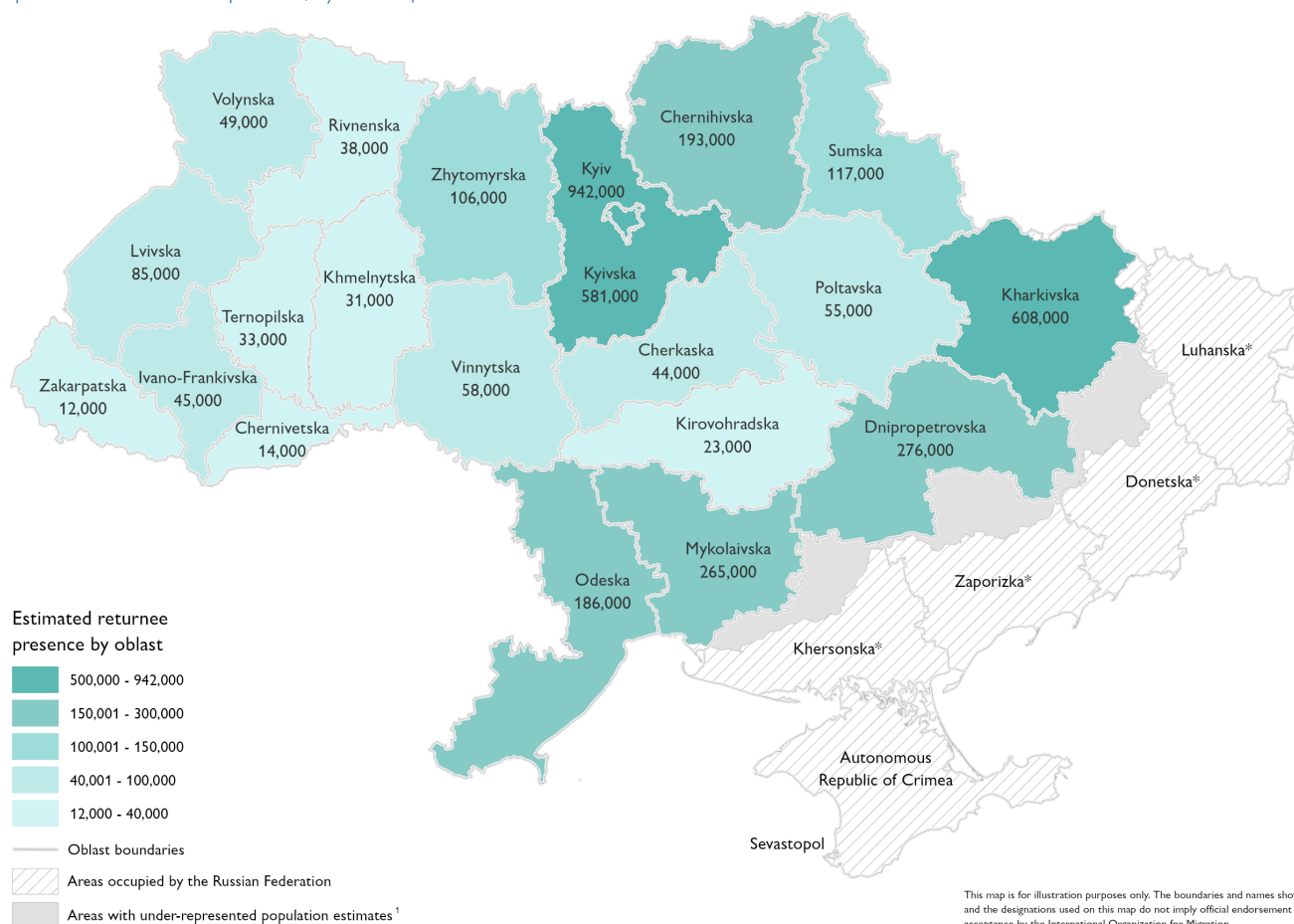


Overall, returnees were only slightly more likely than the non-displaced to have relied on coping strategies. However, they did report comparably greater use of specific coping strategies, such as having relied on humanitarian assistance (29%), having skipped rent payments (11%), having sent household members elsewhere to eat / live, having sold housing or land (8% each), or having moved to poorer-quality housing (7%). Moreover, there were regional differences, with a greater reliance among returnees, compared to the non-displaced, on more severe coping strategies in the Centre and the West of the country, while returnees in Eastern and Southern oblasts were more frequently relying on humanitarian assistance.

SECTION 1: POPULATION FIGURES AND MOBILITY TRENDS

I.1 OVERVIEW AND CHANGE OVER TIME

Map 1: Estimated returnee presence, by oblast of return



3,757,000

EST. TOTAL DE FACTO IDPs

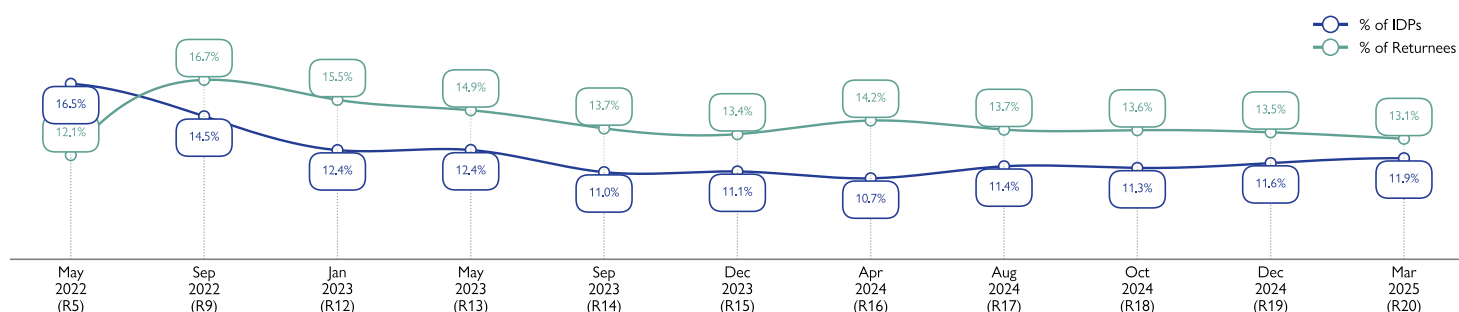
Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) are individuals who have been forced to flee or to leave their homes or who are staying outside their habitual residences in Ukraine due to the full-scale invasion in February 2022, regardless of whether they hold registered IDP status.²

4,137,000

EST. TOTAL RETURNEES

Returnees are individuals who have returned to their habitual residences after a period of displacement of a minimum of two weeks since February 2022, whether from abroad or from internal displacement within Ukraine.²

Figure 1: Share of IDPs and returnees in the total population in Ukraine over time³



¹Estimates in Donetsk, Zaporizka, Luhanska, and Khersonska Oblasts are not shown due to underestimation as a result of survey coverage being limited to government-controlled areas and limited numbers of respondents being reached in occupied areas.

²A complete definition of IDP and returnees, as understood in the context of the GPS, can be found in the [Methodological Note](#) on page 13.

³With each successive round of the GPS, adjustments to the methodology have been made to maximise the accuracy of the estimates provided. Starting from R17 (June 2024), adjustments have been applied retroactively to the percentages provided in previously published rounds, reflecting the most accurate understanding of displacement currently and historically. For detailed information on these changes, please refer to the [Methodological Note](#).

I.2 PLACE OF LAST DISPLACEMENT PRIOR TO RETURN

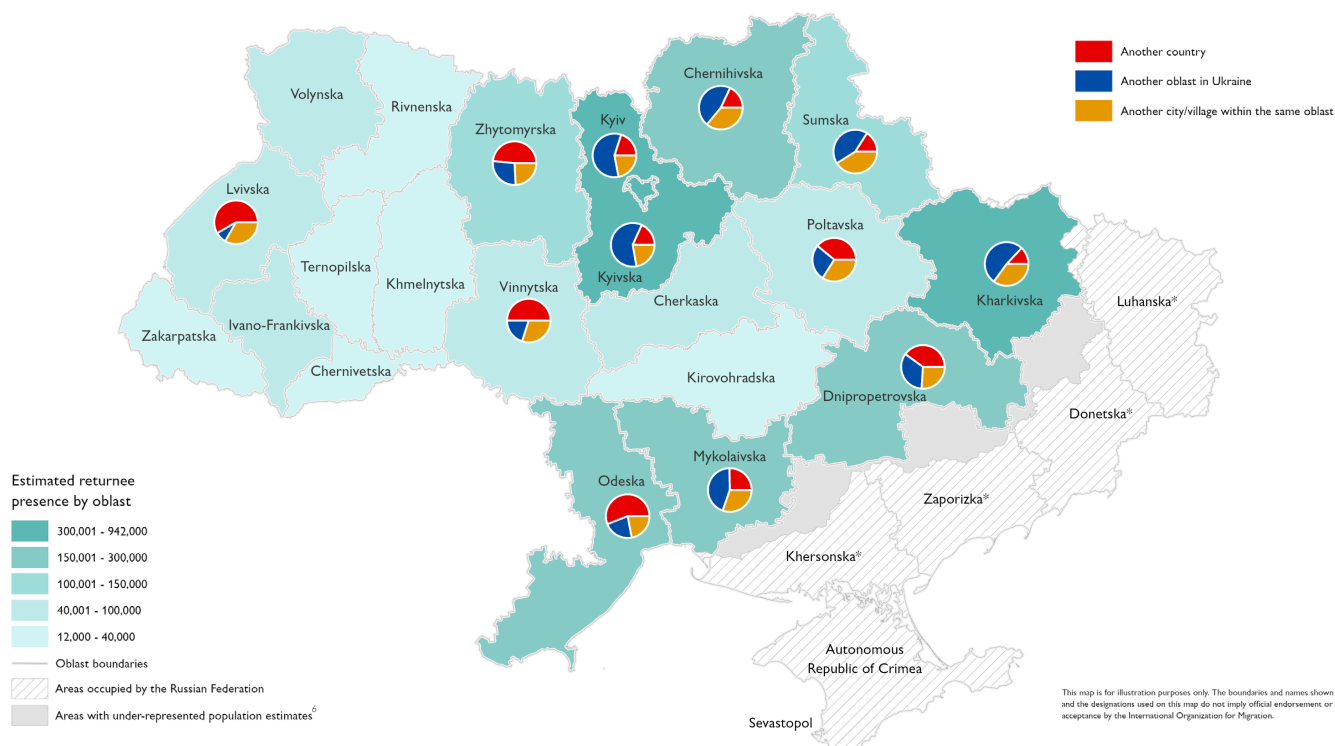
Nearly half of all returnees (48%, 1,971,000 individuals) had returned from a different oblast within the country (inter-oblast returns), while just over one-fourth (26%, 1,084,000 individuals) had last been displaced within their oblasts of origin (intra-oblast returns). An additional 26 per cent of returnees (1,068,000 individuals) had returned directly from abroad, of whom 86 per cent from European Union countries, most commonly from Poland (383,000 returnees), Germany (167,000), and the Czech Republic (56,000).

Returnees from abroad were evenly distributed across most macro-regions, with 16 to 22 per cent having returned to each macro-region but the Centre (8%).⁴ However, due to lower levels of internal returns to

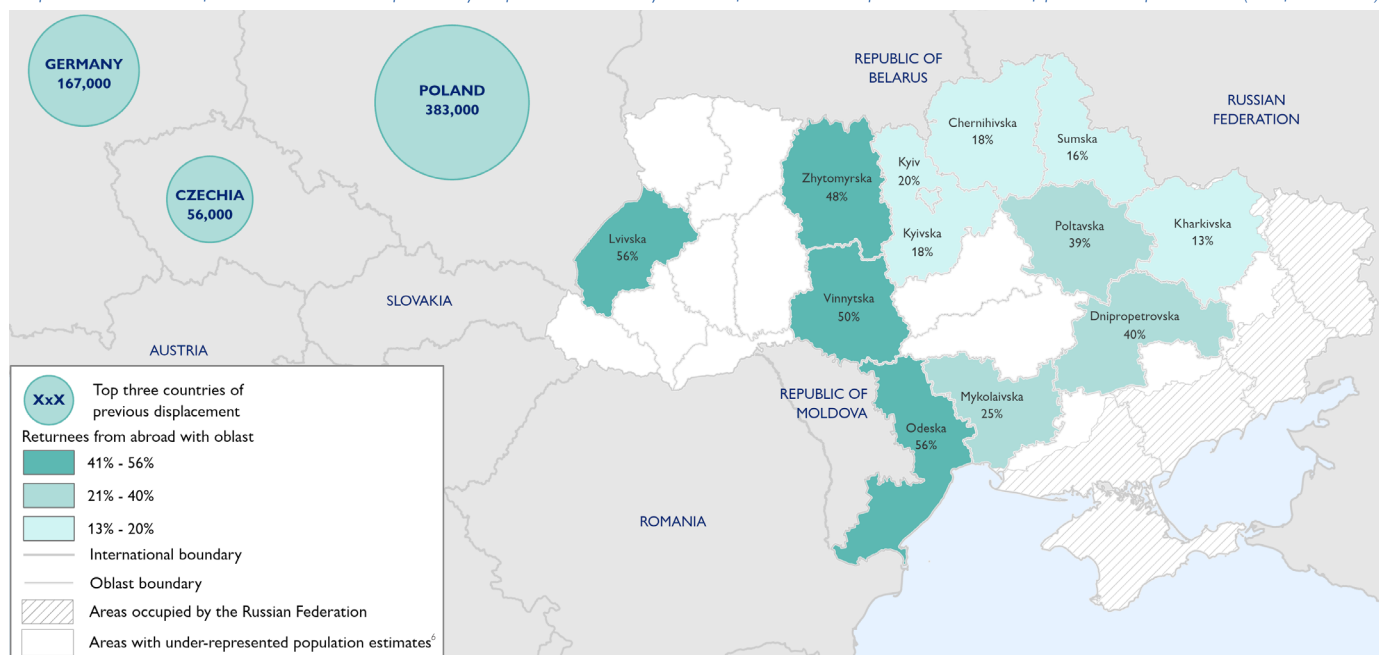
the West, returnees from abroad made up the majority of the returnee population in the West (57%), and in the Centre (46%), while in the rest of the country, they accounted for 20 to 32 per cent of the returnee population.

Intra-oblast returns accounted for 20 to 30 per cent of returns across most of the oblasts that hosted the largest numbers of returnees. Comparably higher levels of intra-oblast returns were observed in Sumska (41%), Chernihivska (36%), and Kharkivska (35%) Oblasts. Notably lower intra-oblast return rates were found in Donetskka (10%) and Khersonska (8%) Oblasts, both of which experienced predominantly inter-oblast returns (83% and 86%, respectively).

Map 2: Displacement location of returnees, by oblast



Map 3: Est. number of returnees who were previously displaced abroad, by oblast of return, and top three countries of previous displacement (% of returnees)



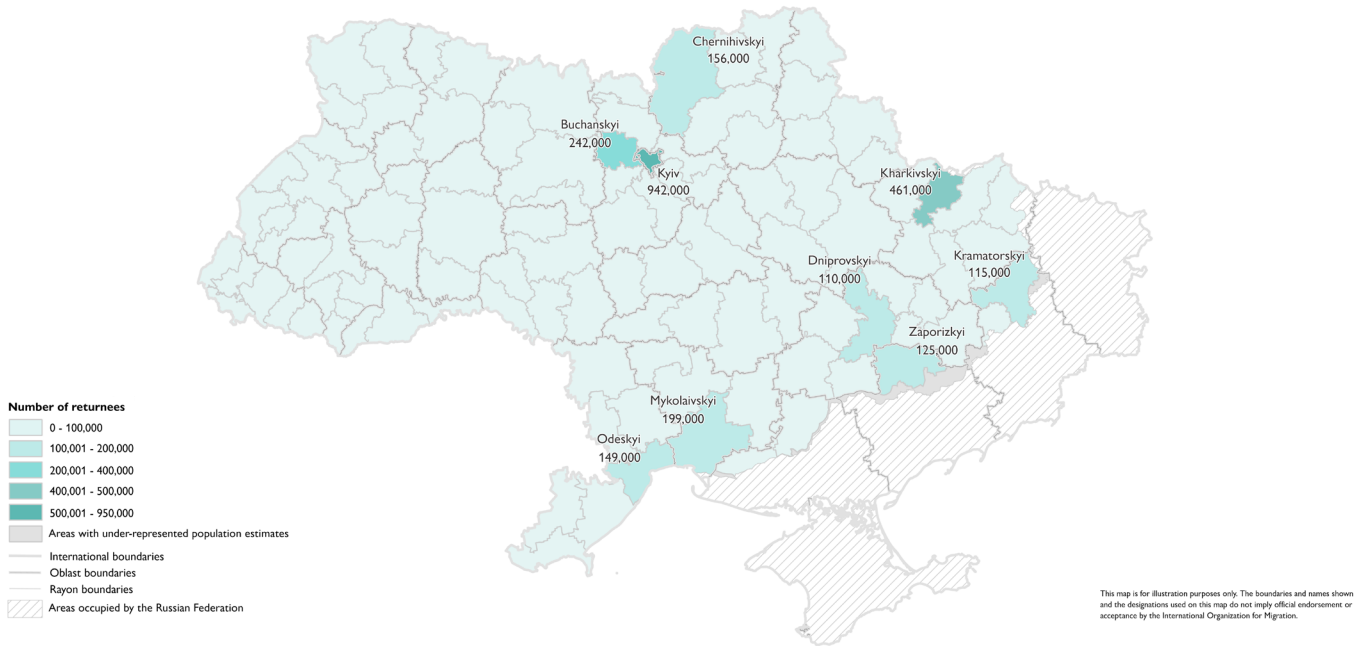
⁴For the purpose of this analysis, macro-regions are defined as follows: Center – Cherkaska, Kirovohradska, Poltavka, Vinnytska; East – Dnipropetrovska, Donetskka, Kharkivska, Zaporizka; Kyiv – Kyiv City; North – Chernihivska, Kyivska, Sumska, Zhytomyrska; South – Khersonska, Mykolaivska, Odeska; West – Chernivetska, Ivano-Frankivska, Khmelnytska, Lvivska, Rivnenska, Ternopiiska, Volynska, Zakarpatska.

⁵Results for non-responders (estimated 0.3%, 13,000 returnees) are excluded from the figure.

⁶Estimates in Donetskka, Zaporizka, Luhanska, and Khersonska Oblasts are not shown due to underestimation as a result of survey coverage being limited to government-controlled areas and limited numbers of respondents being reached in occupied areas.

1.3 RETURN DYNAMICS AND MOBILITY INTENTIONS

Map 4: Estimated number of returnees, by raion of return (all raions)



RETURN DYNAMICS

Table 1: Top 5 oblasts of return (% and est. number of returnees)

Oblast	% of returnees	Est. returnees
Kyiv City	23%	942,000
Kharkivska	15%	608,000
Kyivska	14%	581,000
Dnipropetrovska	7%	276,000
Mykolaivska	6%	265,000
Other oblasts	35%	1,465,000

The median duration of displacement among returnees was 90 days, while over half (52%) the returnees had returned more than two years prior to data collection – likely reflecting returns following brief periods of displacement during the initial phase of the full-scale invasion. Three-fourths (77%) of returnees had returned more than a year prior to data collection.

90

median number of days in displacement before return (as of April 2025)

Over time, intra-oblast returns have become more prevalent, accounting for 43 per cent of the most recent returns.⁷ In contrast, inter-oblast returns, which made up half the returns among those who returned more than one year prior to data collection, have declined, comprising only 29% of returns among those who returned in the three months prior to data collection.

Figure 3: Last location before return, by time since return (% of returnees)

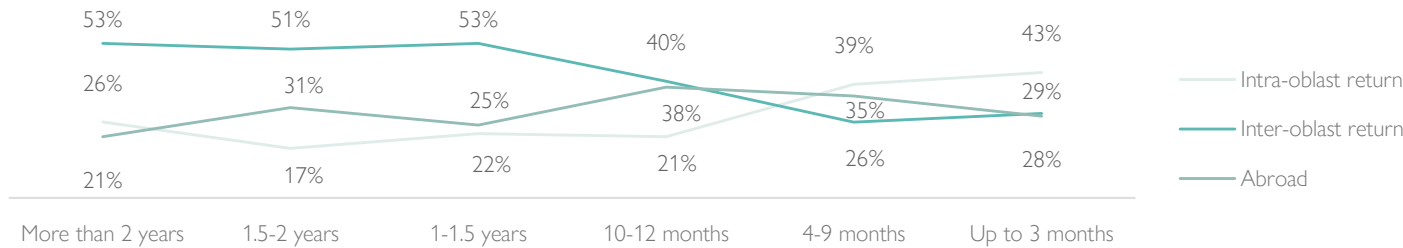
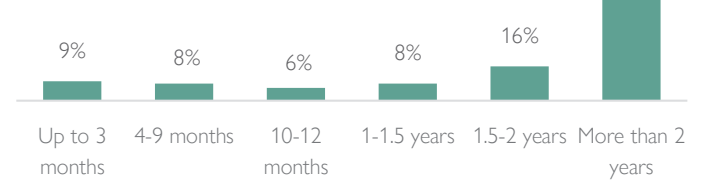


Table 2: Top 5 oblasts of last displacement prior to return (% and est. number of returnees who returned from within Ukraine)

Oblast	% of returnees	Est. returnees
Kyiv City	9%	260,000
Lvivska	8%	228,000
Kharkivska	7%	224,000
Dnipropetrovska	6%	189,000
Vinnytska	6%	187,000
Other oblasts	64%	1,939,000

Figure 2: Time since return (% of returnees)



The majority of returns that took place in the three months prior to data collection occurred to or within Kyiv City (25%; 88,000 returnees), as well as to settlements in oblasts along or close to the frontline: Kharkivska (18%; 64,000), Dnipropetrovska (6%; 22,000), Zaporizka (6%; 20,000), and Odeska (6%; 20,000) Oblasts.

Among recent returnees who had returned from within Ukraine, the largest shares had returned from or within Kyiv City (17%; 44,000), as well as Kharkivska (16%; 42,000), Vinnytska (9%; 24,000), Kyivska (7%; 19,000), and Dnipropetrovska (7%; 17,000) Oblasts.

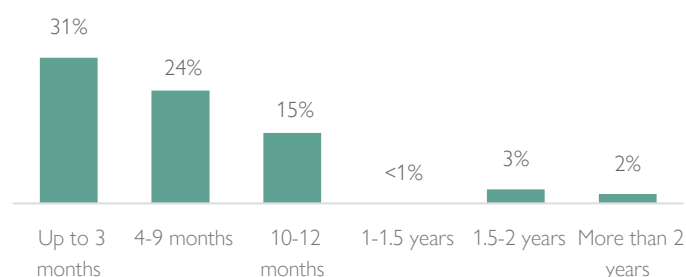
⁷Most recent returns refers to returns that took place in the three months prior to data collection. It has to be noted that, given the two-months data collection period, this refers to a five-months period from early November 2024 to early April 2025. Estimates may therefore overlap with those from previous rounds and cannot be added up across rounds.

MOBILITY INTENTIONS

Similar to last round, seven per cent of returnees – 280,000 individuals – reported that they were considering leaving their current locations in the three months following data collection. Among those, intentions were nearly evenly split between relocating to another oblast in Ukraine (35%), to another location within the same oblast (28%), or to another country (31%).⁸

Also comparable to last round, there was a correlation between the length of time that had passed since return and returnees' onward movement intentions. Returnees who had returned only three months prior to data collection were the most likely to consider leaving again in the three months following data collection, with 31% considering moving. This proportion declined to 15 per cent among those who had returned 10 to 12 months prior to data collection,

Figure 4: Returnees intending to leave their current locations in the three months following data collection, by time since return (% returnees)



and fell to below 5 per cent among returnees who had returned more than a year prior to data collection.

1.4 RETURN TO FRONTLINE AREAS

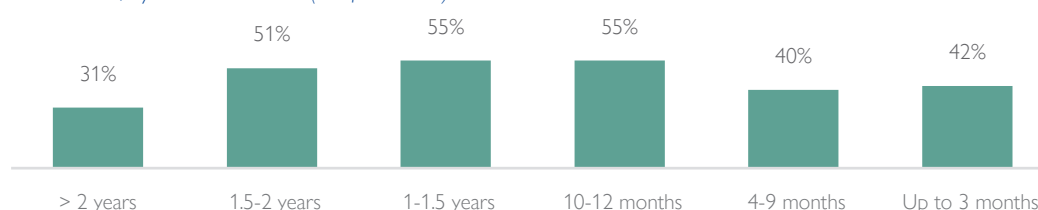
Since the full-scale invasion in February 2022, more than one-third (37%) of returnees had returned to frontline areas.⁹ These returns primarily took place from oblasts which themselves are close to, or contain, frontline areas: Kharkivska (16%), Dnipropetrovska (12%), Poltavaska (9%), Mykolaivska (7%), and Chernihivska (5%) Oblasts. In contrast, the largest return movements to settlements in non-frontline areas took place from or within less war-affected oblasts – Lvivska (10%), Vinnytska (8%), Cherkaska (8%) – as well as Kyiv City (13%), and surrounding Kyivska Oblast.

Overall, the largest numbers of returnees had returned to raions that include major urban centres – in addition to Kyiv City (942,000 returnees), to Kharkivskiyi (Kharkivska Oblast) (461,000), Buchanskyyi (Kyivska Oblast) (242,000), Mykolaivskiyi (Mykolaivska Oblast) (199,000), and Chernihivskiyi (Chernihivska Oblast) (156,000) Raions. In frontline areas, roughly half of all returnees (54%) had returned to large cities or their suburbs. However, this share was notably higher in some frontline oblasts: 76 per cent in Zaporizka, 67 per cent in Chernihivska, and 61 per cent in Kharkivska Oblasts. Other studies confirm that returns to frontline areas, in particular within the 30 km zone of the frontline, may in part be driven by the high concentration of major urban centres in this area.¹⁰

Table 3: Top 5 oblasts of last displacement among returnees in frontline raions (% and est. number of returnees who returned from within Ukraine)

Oblast	% of returnees	Est. returnees
Kharkivska	16%	208,000
Dnipropetrovska	12%	150,000
Poltavska	9%	114,000
Mykolaivska	7%	84,000
Chernihivska	5%	61,000
Other oblasts	51%	654,000

Figure 5: Returns to frontline areas, by time since return (% of returnees)



⁸The remainder (6%) were unsure where they would go.

⁹The list of raions designated as frontline areas for the purpose of this analysis is determined based on the Government of Ukraine's Resolution on "Regulations on the approval of the list of territories on which the Russian Federation is (was) or temporarily occupied", updated as of February 2025. This list includes raions that are either bordering, adjacent to or in proximity of active conflict zones with ongoing fighting, hostilities, or a high likelihood of such activities. Note that all raions are shown on the map, not exclusively frontline raions.

¹⁰REACH (2024) 'Ukraine Brief: What the Data Says About IDP Returns to Unsafe Areas', REACH. Available [here](#) (Accessed: 11 April 2025).

1,549,000
EST. TOTAL RETURNS TO
FRONTLINE RAIONS⁹
(as of the time of data collection)

Returnees who had returned to or within frontline areas tended to be older than those who had returned to settlements in non-frontline areas – 29 per cent were elderly (aged 60+), compared to 19 per cent in non-frontline areas, while another 26 per cent were aged 46 to 59, compared to 21 per cent in non-frontline areas.

Initially, a comparably small proportion of returnees had returned to frontline areas – 31 per cent among those who had returned more than two years prior to data collection. However, this share quickly increased. Among those who had returned within one to two years prior to data collection, more than half had returned to frontline areas, while this proportion has remained at around 40 per cent since.

Table 4: Top 5 oblasts of last displacement among returnees in non-frontline raions (% and est. number of returnees who returned from within Ukraine)

Oblast	% of returnees	Est. returnees
Kyiv City	13%	213,000
Lvivska	10%	168,000
Vinnytska	8%	130,000
Cherkaska	8%	127,000
Kyivska	8%	124,000
Other oblasts	53%	867,000

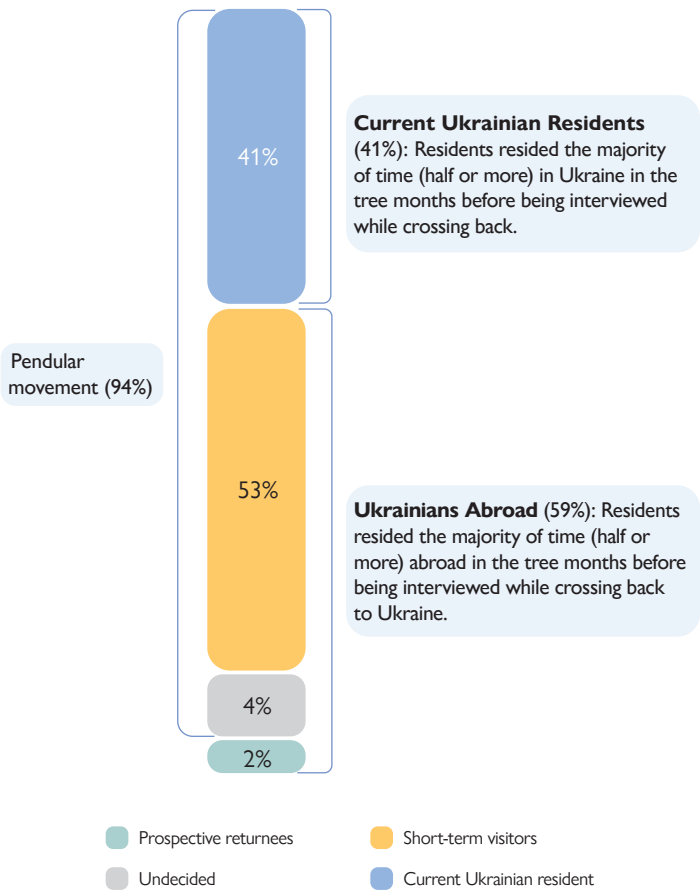
I.5 CROSSING BACK FROM ABROAD

Since March 2022, IOM DTM has conducted surveys with persons crossing back to Ukraine from neighbouring countries and Latvia (via the Russian Federation) to improve the understanding of their profiles, displacement patterns, intentions and needs.¹¹ In Quarter 4 of 2024 (Q4), 2,197 Ukrainian nationals were surveyed at border areas and transit places across Poland, the Republic of Moldova, Romania, and Slovakia. Respondents crossing back from Hungary and Latvia were excluded from the below analysis due to the low number of respondents (19 and 1, respectively).

INTENTIONS

Based on DTM's surveys of Ukrainians crossing back via Poland, the Republic of Moldova, Romania and Slovakia in Q4 2024, almost all movements into Ukraine (94%) are pendular in nature – characterised by short-term stays or temporary returns. The remaining six per cent are prospective returnees and undecided respondents. This highlights that not all individuals leaving Ukraine are doing so to displace; rather, many are engaged in temporary or cyclical movements back and forth across the border.

Figure 6: Categorisation of respondents by mobility history and intention Q4, 2024



The remaining analysis focuses on Ukrainians abroad (respondents who had spent at least 50 per cent of the three months preceding the interview outside of Ukraine). Respondents who spent 50 per cent or more of the three months prior to the interview within Ukraine and were crossing back after a short visit abroad (1,353 respondents) are not included in the below analysis.

DEMOGRAPHICS



As in previously assessed periods, the vast majority of respondents crossing back to Ukraine were female (92%). Women were generally younger than men. Nearly three quarters (71%) of women were below 50 years old compared to only 13 per cent of men.

ORIGINS AND DESTINATIONS

Table 5: Top 7 oblasts of origin and intended oblast of destination among Ukrainians displaced abroad and returning to Ukraine during Q4 2024

Oblast of origin	Share of respondents	Oblast of destination	Share of respondents
Odeska	20%	Odeska	23%
Kyiv City	11%	Vinnytska	15%
Vinnytska	11%	Kyiv City	12%
Kyivska	6%	Kyivska	6%
Mykolaivska	6%	Zakarpatska	5%
Dnipropetrovska	5%	Mykolaivska	5%
Kharkivska	4%	Dnipropetrovska	4%
Other	37%	Other	30%

The share of respondents originating from each oblast in Ukraine varied widely among the respondents in neighbouring countries. Overall, more than half (54%) of respondents resided in just five oblasts prior to being displaced from Ukraine: Odeska (20%), Kyiv City (11%), Vinnytska (11%), Kyivska (6%), and Mykolaivska (6%) Oblasts. A very high proportion of respondents (86%) expressed their intention to return to their oblast of origin upon re-entry to Ukraine.

Among those planning to travel to another oblast, reasons included concerns about security in their place of origin (37%), their oblast of origin being too far (24%) having their family displaced to another area (18%), or knowledge of damage or destruction to their homes (12%).

NEEDS UPON ARRIVAL IN UKRAINE

The most reported immediate needs individuals anticipated upon arriving at their destination in Ukraine were financial support (34%), health services (23%), general information (20%), medicine (15%), long-term accommodation (7%), and personal hygiene and sanitary supplies (7%).

¹¹For more information on the work of the DTM in Ukraine's neighboring countries, as well as for further analysis, please visit [DTM Ukraine Response](#)

I.6 DEMOGRAPHICS, VULNERABILITIES AND SETTLEMENT TYPE

A detailed disaggregation of IDP profiles and greater insights into the prevalence of vulnerabilities¹² and household composition enables an enhanced understanding of mobility and is key to an effective, targeted humanitarian response. To this end, IOM's GPS includes indicators – developed in cooperation with the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) – which allow for precise estimated demographic breakdowns of the displaced population. **This section specifically outlines the estimates for returnees in households consisting exclusively of returnees.**

HOUSEHOLD COMPOSITION

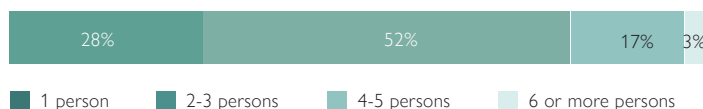
AS OF APRIL 2025



Figure 7: Number of children in returnee-only households (% of returnees in returnee-only households with children)



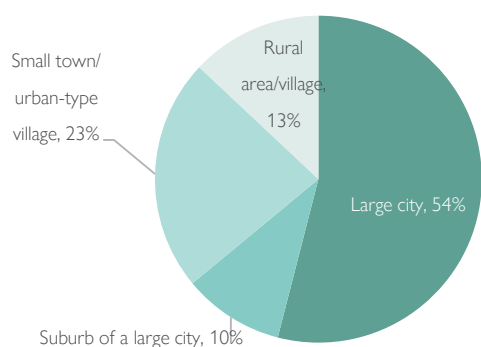
Figure 8: Number of household members in returnee-only households (% of returnees in returnee-only households)



SETTLEMENT TYPE

The majority of returnees in returnee-only households (54%) resided in large cities or their suburbs (10%). One-fourth (23%) had returned to small towns, and another 13 per cent to rural areas.

Figure 9: Share of returnees in returnee-only households by settlement type

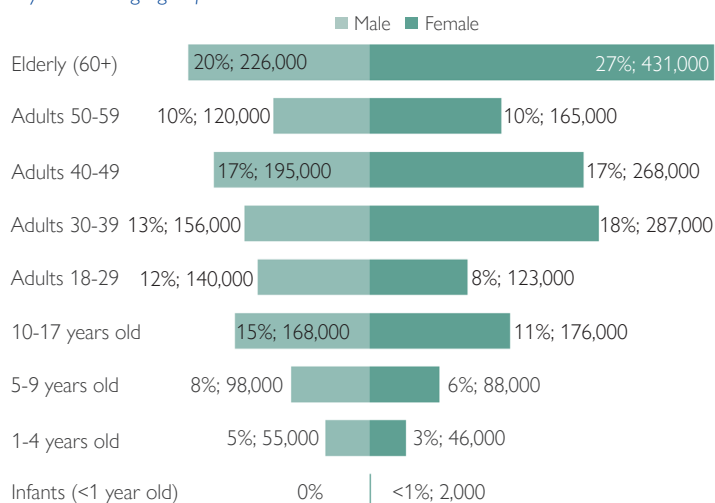


DEMOGRAPHIC PROFILE

The majority of returnees in returnee-only households were female (58%), while 42 per cent were male. Most returnees in these households were of working age (53%), and one-fourth each were children (23%) or elderly individuals (aged 60+; 24%).

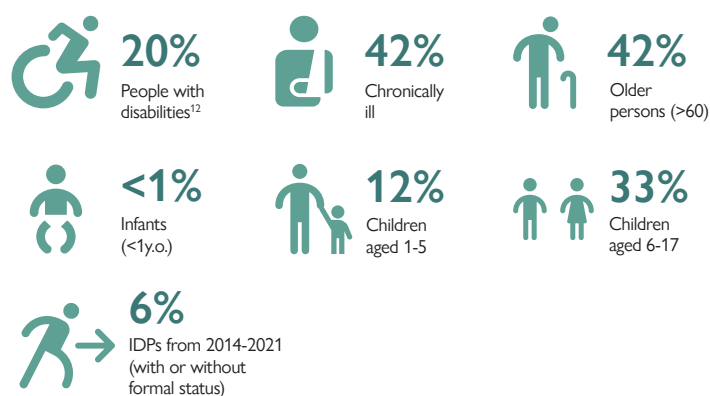


Figure 10: Estimated number and share of returnees in returnee-only households, by sex and age group



HOUSEHOLD CHARACTERISTICS

The following figures illustrate the share of IDPs in IDP-only households who reported that at least one household member had one or more of the assessed characteristics. These traits may contribute to household vulnerability due to: 1) presumed associated costs; 2) a likely need for assistance; and 3) potential challenges in getting to or accessing assistance. These characteristics are not mutually exclusive, meaning that individuals or households may live with one or more of the following characteristics:¹⁴



¹²To identify household members with disabilities and chronic illnesses, respondents were asked if anyone in their household had a disability or chronic illness based on World Health Organization definitions. For shorter and simple questions, a modified approach to the Washington Group methodology to assess disability was used.

¹³As reported by respondents in households with at least one child. The estimated total number of children in returnee-only households was 632,000.

¹⁴Multiple answers were possible.

SECTION 2: PRIORITY NEEDS AND COPING STRATEGIES

2.1 OVERVIEW

Assistance needs were assessed using a two-step approach. First, respondents were asked whether they had had sufficient access to a list of pre-defined goods and services to meet their basic needs. If they reported a lack of access to any of these items, they were then asked to identify which of these represented their most pressing need.

Overall, three-fourths of returnees (75%) reported insufficient access to at least one good or service. Most commonly, returnees reported insufficient access to income-earning opportunities (33%), power banks or generators (28%), medicines (27%), building or reconstruction materials, and health services (26% each).

National-level results among returnees were similar to those obtained among the non-displaced population, with a few notable exceptions. Higher shares of returnees than non-displaced reported insufficient access particularly to power banks or generators (28%, compared to 22%), adequate education (23%, compared to 17%), income-earning opportunities (33%, compared to 28%), and mental health services (20%, compared to 15%).

Access gaps reduced slightly compared to the previous round. In December 2024, 79 per cent of returnees had reported at least one access gap, whereas this figure dropped to 75 per in the current round.

When asked to identify their single most pressing need, returnees most often highlighted the need for income-earning opportunities (15%), adequate education (10%), and medicines (7%).

With the exception of access to education, returnees' primary needs were also broadly comparable to those of the non-displaced. The higher reported need for education was likely to some degree driven by a greater likelihood of children in returnee households, compared to non-displaced households. However, even when comparing only households with children, returnees were slightly more likely than the non-displaced to report access to education as their primary need: Among respondents in households with children, 18 per cent of returnees reported access to adequate education as their most pressing need, compared to 14 per cent of the non-displaced.

Overall, returnees' level of access to goods and services – at least with respect to the goods and services assessed here – therefore appeared almost comparable to that of the non-displaced population. However, there were regional differences, with greater disparities in the Centre (80 per cent of returnees reported access gaps, compared to 71 per cent of the non-displaced), South (82%, compared to 77%), and West (75%, compared to 68%) than in Kyiv City (67%, compared to 65%). In Eastern oblasts, since round 17 of the GPS conducted in July 2024, returnees' level of access had been slightly below that of the non-displaced, while reversing this round (78%, compared to 82%). Lastly, in the Northern oblasts, levels of access have been comparable for both population groups since round 17, with greater disparity only this round (76%, compared to 70%). Thus, while returnees were notably less likely to face access gaps than IDPs, they may not yet always have re-established levels of access equal to the non-displaced, indicating that durable solutions may not yet always have been achieved.

Insufficient access to goods and services in areas of return may – among other factors – contribute to returns becoming unsustainable. Among returnees who had reported access gaps, one in ten

Figure 11: Top 3 primary material and assistance needs, by respondent profile

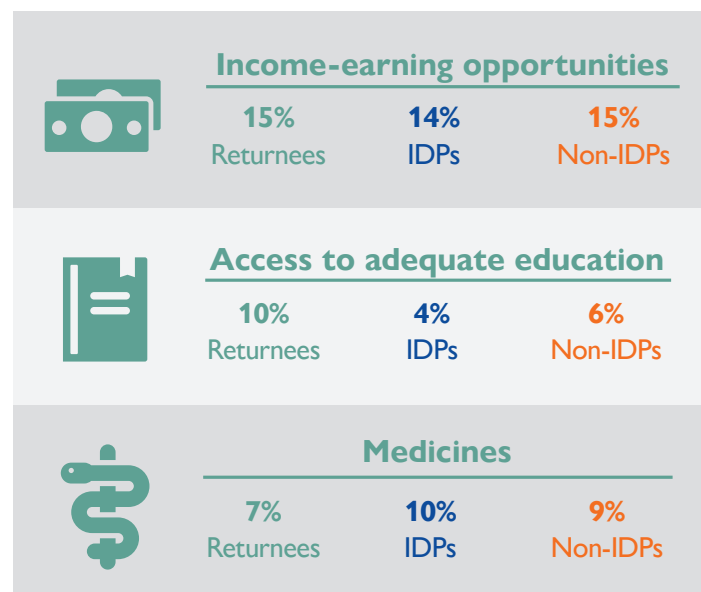


Table 6: Lack of access to goods and services, by displacement status (% of returnees / non-displaced reporting having had insufficient access to goods and services to be able to meet basic needs)

Category	Returnees	Non-displaced
Income-earning opportunities	33%	28%
Power banks and generators	28%	22%
Medicines	27%	30%
Building / reconstruction materials	26%	31%
Health services	26%	27%
Access to adequate education	23%	17%
Mental health services	20%	15%
Food	20%	18%
Support for people with disabilities	18%	21%
Legal consulting services	13%	13%
Hygiene items	13%	12%
Accommodation	11%	8%
Clothes and other NFIs	11%	12%
Access to money (e.g. ATMs)	7%	8%
Transportation & evacuation support	7%	6%
None of the above	25%	27%

individuals (11%) were planning to leave their current locations in the short or medium term – notably more than the three per cent among returnees who had not reported any access gaps. Additionally, eight per cent of returnees who had faced access gaps intended to leave their current locations within the three months following data collection, compared to just three per cent of those who had not.

2.2 NEEDS BY LOCATION & SOCIO-ECONOMIC CHARACTERISTICS

OBLAST-LEVEL

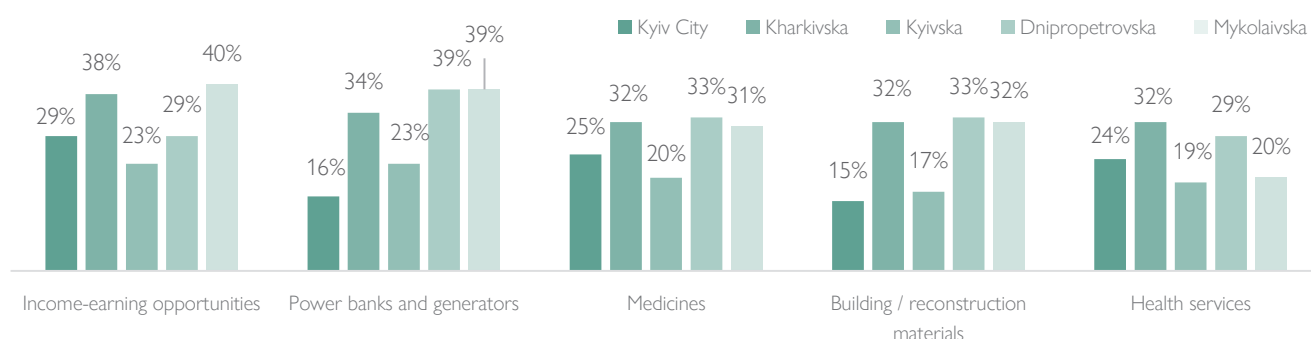
Access gaps were least prevalent in Kyiv City, where one-third (33%) of returnees had not reported any access gaps. In Northern and Western oblasts, one-fourth of returnees (24% and 25%, respectively) had had access to all assessed goods and services, while in other regions, this figure declined to between 18 to 22 per cent.

In Western oblasts, the need for income-earning opportunities was especially acute. Nearly one in four (23%) returnees identified this as their primary need – notably higher than the 12 to 18 per cent reported elsewhere. Returnees in Kyiv City (8%) and Western oblasts (6%) were also more likely to cite access to mental health services as their most pressing need, compared to just two to four per cent in other parts of the country. Additionally, in Western oblasts, 10 per cent of returnees identified access to health

services – rather than medicines – as their top need. Conversely, an urgent need for education was less reported in the West (1%) and in Kyiv City (4%), while more prevalent in other parts of the country (11% to 15%) – where needs otherwise broadly reflected the overall results among returnees.

Access gaps were generally more pronounced in frontline areas, where 80 per cent of returnees reported at least one gap, compared to 73 per cent of returnees in non-frontline areas, and as compared to 79 and 71 per cent of the non-displaced in frontline and non-frontline areas, respectively. In particular, the need for building / reconstruction materials was more frequently reported, with 10 per cent of returnees in frontline areas having identified this as their primary need – double the proportion of returnees in non-frontline areas (5%).

Figure 12: Share of returnees reporting insufficient access to goods and services to meet basic needs in top 5 returnee-hosing oblasts (top 5 items, % of returnees)¹⁵

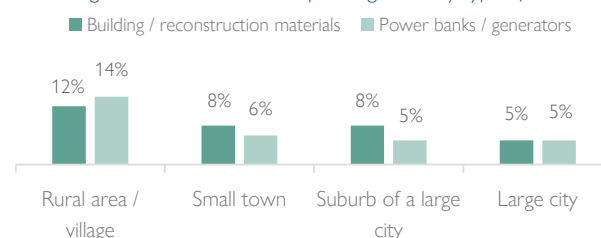


SETTLEMENT TYPE



Building or reconstruction materials, as well as power banks / generators, more commonly a pressing need in rural areas.

Figure 13: Share of returnees reporting building / reconstruction materials or power banks / generators as their most pressing need, by type of settlement

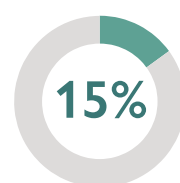


SOCIO-ECONOMIC CHARACTERISTICS

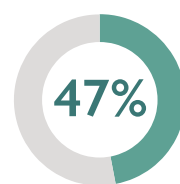
Female returnees were slightly more likely to report access gaps: 77% of female returnees indicated at least one gap, compared to 73% of male returnees. Women more frequently reported insufficient access to goods, such as power banks or generators (30%, compared to 25%), medicines (29%, compared to 24%), food (21%, compared to 18%), hygiene items (15%, compared to 9%), and clothing or other NFIs (12%, compared to 8%), as well as to education (25%, compared to 19%), mental health services (23%, compared to 13%), and transportation / evacuation support (8%, compared to 5%). In contrast, men were more likely to report insufficient access to services, such as health services (28%, compared to 24%) and legal consulting services (16%, compared to 12%), as well as to money (11%, compared to 5%), and to income-earning opportunities (35%, compared to 32%).

Moreover, returnees in households with persons with disabilities or with chronically ill members were more likely to report access gaps (85 and 82 per cent, respectively) than returnees in households without such members (72 and 71 per cent, respectively, of returnees in households without such members).

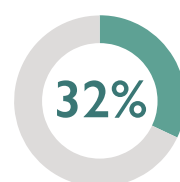
Lastly, 85 per cent of returnees in low-income households (income below the Minimum Expenditure Basket (MEB)¹⁶) reported gaps, compared to 68 per cent of returnees in higher-income households.



15% of female returnees reported insufficient access to hygiene items, compared to 9% of male returnees.



47% of returnees in households with persons with disabilities reported insufficient access to medicines, compared to 21% of returnees in households without persons with disabilities.



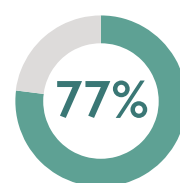
32% of returnees in households with an income below the MEB reported insufficient access to food, compared to 9% of returnees in households with an income above the MEB.

¹⁵Multiple answers possible.

¹⁶The MEB is set at UAH 6,318 per person.

2.3 COPING STRATEGIES

Returnees were slightly more likely than the non-displaced to report having relied on livelihoods-based coping strategies to meet their basic needs. Among a list of ten defined strategies, 77 per cent of returnees reported that their households had either adopted at least one of these strategies in the 30 days prior to data collection, or had already exhausted them. In comparison, 73 per cent of non-displaced individuals reported the adoption or exhaustion of at least one of these coping strategies to meet household needs.



of returnees reported their households to have adopted or exhausted livelihoods-based coping strategies, compared to 73 per cent of the non-displaced.

Table 7: Severity of livelihoods-based coping (% of respondents reporting their households to have adopted or exhausted livelihoods-based coping strategies to meet basic needs in the 30 days prior to data collection, by severity level and displacement status)¹⁷

Coping strategy	IDPs	Returnees	Non-displaced
Stress	23%	25%	23%
Sold household assets / goods	20%	16%	11%
Spent savings	72%	63%	55%
Purchased food on credit / borrowed food	16%	12%	11%
Accepted lower-qualification / low-paid job	34%	29%	23%
Crisis	34%	30%	29%
Sold productive assets / means of transport	16%	13%	8%
Reduced essential health expenditures	51%	42%	38%
Reduced essential education expenditures	12%	13%	9%
Emergency	30%	23%	21%
Sold house / land	10%	8%	4%
Used degrading income source (illegal / high-risk jobs)	15%	13%	13%
Asked strangers for money to cover essential needs	12%	9%	8%

In the 30 days prior to data collection, most commonly, returnee households had relied on spending savings or on reducing utility usage – 53 per cent of returnees reported their households to have adopted each of these strategies during this timeframe. Moreover, 39 per cent of returnees reported a reduction in health expenditures, while 21 per cent reported that their household members had accepted lower-skilled or lower-paid jobs, and one-fifth (20%) reported reliance on humanitarian assistance as a coping strategy.

While these strategies may help households meet their needs in the short term, their adoption is not sustainable over time. Continued reliance on such strategies may weaken household resilience and reduce coping capacities in the long term if households are unable to gain access to sufficient sustainable sources of income.

Notably, 10 per cent of returnees reported that their households had already exhausted their savings, and nine per cent stated that they could no longer rely on humanitarian assistance.

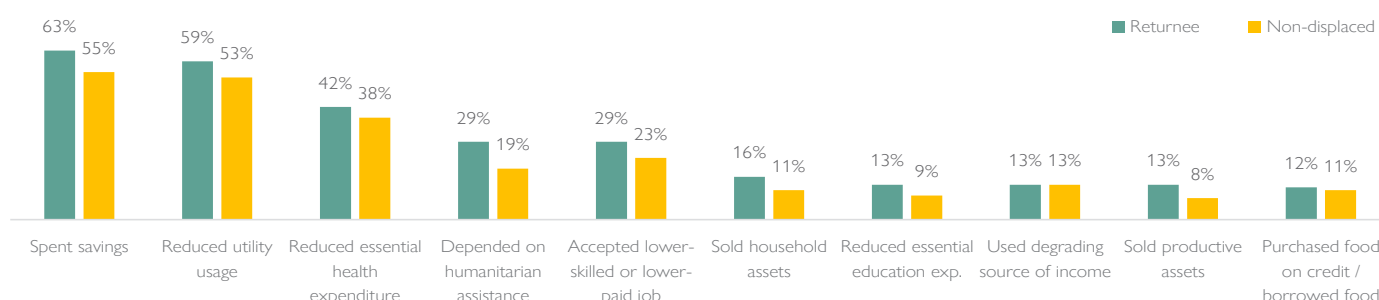
Overall, returnees were also only slightly more likely than the non-displaced to report that their households had adopted or exhausted crisis- or emergency-level livelihoods-based coping strategies. These are strategies, which are more extreme in nature, negatively affect

a household's future productivity and / or are extremely difficult to reverse. In total, 53 per cent of returnees reported the adoption or exhaustion of crisis- or emergency-level coping strategies, compared to 50 per cent of the non-displaced.

Despite overall comparable levels of reliance (adoption or exhaustion) on coping strategies among returnees and among the non-displaced, returnees were noticeably more likely to report having relied on humanitarian assistance (29%, compared to 19% among the non-displaced). In addition, seven per cent of returnees reported their households to have moved to poorer-quality housing – almost four times the rate observed among the non-displaced (2%) – while returnees were also twice as likely to report having skipped rent payments (11%, compared to 6%), sent household members elsewhere to eat or live, or having sold housing or land (in both cases, 8%, compared to 4%).

Notably, the rate of reliance on emergency-level livelihoods-based coping strategies has slightly increased among returnees since the previous round of data collection in December 2024, when 16 per cent of returnees had reported the adoption or exhaustion of such coping strategies.

Figure 14: Most commonly adopted or exhausted livelihoods-based coping strategies (top 10), % by displacement status¹⁷



¹⁷The classification of strategies into stress-, crisis-, and emergency-level strategies is based on the categories used by REACH and the World Food Programme in Ukraine in 2024. In the aggregate analysis, the proportion of respondents reporting their households to have adopted or exhausted stress-, crisis- or emergency-level livelihoods-based are mutually exclusive. They reflect the level of the most severe coping strategy adopted / exhausted. Multiple answers possible.

REGIONAL LEVEL

Reliance on crisis- or emergency-level livelihoods-based coping strategies was highest in the East and South of the country, where 61 and 60 per cent, respectively, of returnees reported that their households had adopted or exhausted such coping strategies. In contrast, approximately half of returnees in the West (55%), Centre (54%), and North (50%) reported the same, while the level of reliance on crisis- or emergency-level coping strategies was lowest in Kyiv City (41%).

These results were comparable to those obtained among the non-displaced in the North, East, and to a lesser extent, the South. In Northern oblasts, 50 per cent of returnees and 52 per cent of the non-displaced reported that their households had adopted or exhausted crisis- or emergency-level livelihoods-based coping strategies to meet basic needs. In the East, 61 per cent of returnees and 58 per cent of the non-displaced reported the same, while in Southern oblasts, 60 per cent of returnees and 54 per cent of the non-displaced reported reliance on such coping strategies.

However, in the West and Centre, returnees reported notably higher reliance on crisis- or emergency-level coping strategies – 55 per cent of returnees, compared to 44 per cent of the non-

displaced in the West, and 54 and 45 per cent, respectively, in the Centre.

In contrast, in Kyiv City, returnees were notably less reliant than the non-displaced on such coping strategies to meet household needs (41%, compared to 51%).

At the same time, especially in the East and South of the country, returnees reported notably higher reliance than the non-displaced on humanitarian assistance. In the East, nearly half of all returnees (49%) reported that their households had relied on humanitarian assistance as a coping strategy, compared to just one-third (35%) of the non-displaced. Similarly, in the South, 43 per cent of returnees and 31 per cent of the non-displaced reported reliance on humanitarian assistance to be able to meet needs.

These findings suggest that in Kyiv City and the Northern oblasts – likely in part driven by the high concentration of returnees in Kyivska Oblast – returnees' ability to meet needs may be comparable to that of the non-displaced. However, in other parts of the country, returnees continue to rely more heavily on coping strategies more broadly, or on humanitarian assistance specifically.

Figure 15: Share of returnees and non-displaced reporting their households to have adopted or exhausted crisis- or emergency livelihoods-based coping strategies¹⁸

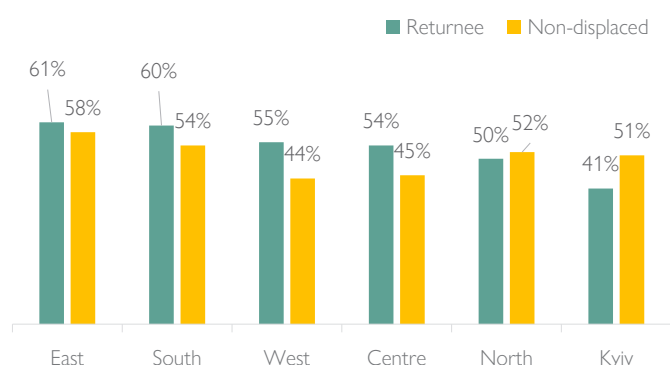
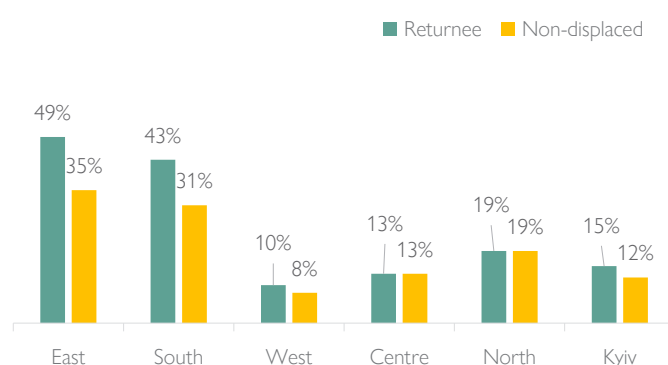


Figure 16: Share of returnees and non-displaced reporting their households to have relied on (adopted or exhausted) humanitarian assistance as a coping strategy

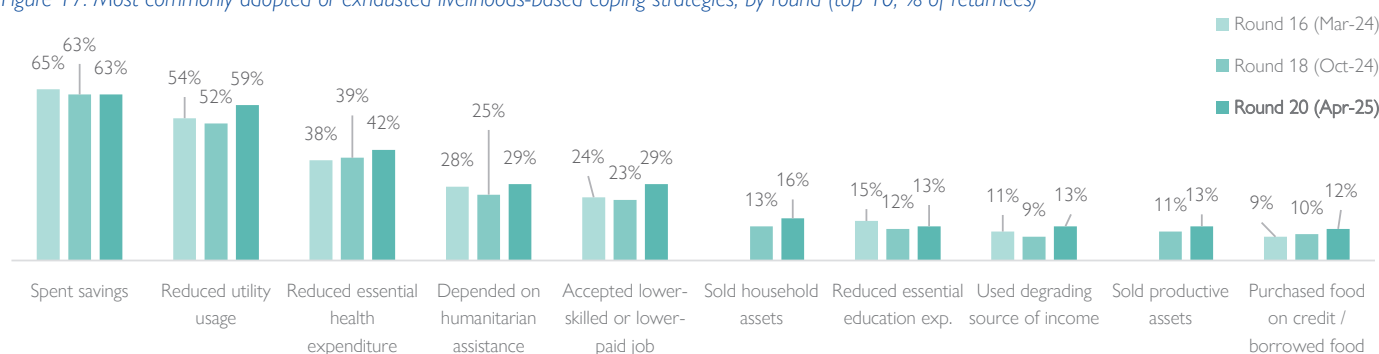


CHANGE OVER TIME

Overall reliance on livelihoods-based coping strategies has remained similar to March 2024. However, reliance on a few coping strategies has increased. Currently, nearly six in ten (59%) returnees report their households to have reduced utility usage as a means to cope, up from 54 per cent in the previous year.

Additionally, a higher proportion of returnees now report having reduced health expenditures (42%, compared to 38% a year earlier), accepted lower-skilled jobs (29%, compared to 24%), or purchased food on credit (12%, compared to 9%).

Figure 17: Most commonly adopted or exhausted livelihoods-based coping strategies, by round (top 10, % of returnees)¹⁹



¹⁸The classification of strategies into stress-, crisis-, and emergency-level strategies is based on the categories used by REACH and the World Food Programme in Ukraine in 2024. In the aggregate analysis, the proportion of respondents reporting their households to have adopted or exhausted stress-, crisis- or emergency-level livelihoods-based are mutually exclusive. They reflect the level of the most severe coping strategy adopted / exhausted. Multiple answers possible.

¹⁹Multiple answers possible. Results related to having sold household or productive assets are not comparable for R16, and have therefore been removed.

2.4 COPING STRATEGIES BY SOCIO-ECONOMIC CHARACTERISTICS & MOBILITY

Table 8: Severity of livelihoods-based coping (% of returnees reporting their households to have adopted or exhausted livelihoods-based coping strategies to meet basic needs in the 30 days prior to data collection, by severity level and socio-economic characteristics or mobility intentions)²⁰

Coping strategy	By presence of chronically ill household members		By income relative to the MEB		By location of return		By time passed since return		By short-term movement intentions	
	At least one	None	Below MEB	Above MEB	Frontline	Non-frontline area	Up to 1 year	More than 1 year	Leaving	Staying
None	14%	27%	12%	30%	16%	26%	13%	24%	7%	23%
Stress	20%	28%	18%	31%	25%	25%	22%	25%	19%	25%
Sold household assets / goods	19%	14%	21%	11%	16%	16%	22%	15%	27%	15%
Spent savings	68%	60%	69%	60%	66%	62%	72%	61%	78%	62%
Purchased food on credit / borrowed food	17%	8%	18%	7%	14%	10%	15%	11%	20%	11%
Accepted lower-qualification / low-paid job	32%	26%	37%	22%	30%	28%	32%	28%	33%	28%
Crisis	38%	24%	37%	24%	33%	27%	35%	28%	48%	29%
Sold productive assets / means of transport	17%	10%	17%	10%	12%	13%	15%	12%	21%	12%
Reduced essential health expenditures	56%	32%	58%	29%	46%	38%	54%	38%	68%	39%
Reduced essential education expenditures	13%	13%	15%	12%	14%	12%	17%	12%	19%	12%
Emergency	27%	20%	32%	15%	25%	22%	28%	21%	25%	22%
Sold house / land	8%	7%	10%	5%	8%	7%	9%	7%	11%	7%
Used degrading income source (illegal / high-risk jobs)	16%	11%	17%	10%	13%	13%	13%	13%	11%	13%
Asked strangers for money to cover essential needs	11%	7%	16%	3%	10%	7%	15%	7%	16%	8%

Returnees in households with chronically ill members were more likely to report reliance on livelihoods-based coping strategies than those in households without such members. Nearly two-thirds (65%) of returnees in these households reported the adoption or exhaustion of crisis- or emergency-level strategies, compared to 45 per cent of returnees in households without chronically ill members. This difference was driven by significantly higher reliance on a reduction in essential health expenditures (56%, compared to 32%). Thus, in the absence of other means to meet needs, these households may be forced to cut costs associated with caring for their ill household members.

Returnees in low-income households were notably more likely to have relied on each of the above strategies. Additionally, almost one-third (32%) of returnees in such households reported the adoption or exhaustion of emergency-level coping strategies, compared to just 15 per cent of returnees in higher-income households. Most notably, returnees in low-income households were twice as likely to report the sale of housing or land, and five times as likely to report that their households had resorted to asking strangers for money.

Returnees in frontline areas relied on most of the above strategies to a slightly greater degree than returnees in non-frontline areas. Overall, 83 per cent of returnees in frontline areas reported the adoption or exhaustion of at least one of these strategies, compared to just 73 per cent of returnees in non-frontline areas.

Reliance on coping strategies also varied depending on **when returnees had returned**. Returnees who had returned up to a year prior to data collection were more likely to report household reliance on coping strategies (85%), compared to those who had returned longer ago (75%), including on crisis- or emergency-level strategies (63%, compared to 50%).

Finally, returnees who **planned to leave** their current locations in the short term were notably more likely than those who planned to stay to report that their households had adopted or exhausted any of the above strategies (92%, compared to 76%), particularly crisis- or emergency-level strategies (73%, compared to 51%). As noted above, these findings suggest that an inability to meet needs may contribute to rendering returns unsustainable.

²⁰Multiple answers possible.

ANNEX: ESTIMATED POPULATION BY DISPLACEMENT STATUS

Oblast	Estimated <i>de facto</i> IDP pop. present	Estimated returnee pop. present
Cherkaska	123,000	44,000
Chernihivska	65,000	193,000
Chernivetska	52,000	14,000
Dnipropetrovska	588,000	276,000
Ivano-Frankivska	86,000	45,000
Kharkivska	463,000	608,000
Khmelnitska	89,000	31,000
Kirovohradska	84,000	23,000
Kyiv	370,000	942,000
Kyivska	289,000	581,000
Lvivska	157,000	85,000
Mykolaivska	131,000	265,000
Odeska	202,000	186,000
Poltavska	178,000	55,000
Rivnenska	43,000	38,000
Sumska	130,000	117,000
Ternopil'ska	61,000	33,000
Vinnytska	135,000	58,000
Volynska	38,000	49,000
Zakarpatska	72,000	12,000
Zhytomyrska	70,000	106,000
Donetska ²¹	n/a	n/a
Luhanska ²¹	n/a	n/a
Khersonska ²¹	n/a	n/a
Zaporizka ²¹	n/a	n/a
Residence location unknown (in Ukraine)	10,000	6,000
Total population	3,757,000	4,137,000

A BRIEF NOTE ON THE METHODOLOGY

Unless noted otherwise, data cited in this report were compiled from Round 20 of the General Population Survey, dated as of 4 April 2025. The data presented in this report was commissioned by the International Organization for Migration (IOM) and collected by 68 enumerators employed by Multicultural Insights through screener phone-based interviews with 40,004 randomly selected respondents and follow-up interviews with 1,436 IDPs, 1,137 returnees, and 1,804 non-displaced, using computer-assisted telephone interviews (CATI), and a random digit dial (RDD) approach, with an overall sample error of 0.49% [CL95%]. Round 20 of data collection was completed between 5 February and 4 April 2025. The survey included all of Ukraine, excluding the Crimean Peninsula and occupied areas of Donetska, Luhanska, Khersonska, and Zaporizka Oblasts. All interviews were anonymous, and respondents were asked for consent before starting the interview. IDP and returnee population figures at the national and oblast levels are derived from the July 2024 (updated as of September 27, 2024) total population baseline for Ukraine (excluding the Autonomous Republic of Crimea and Sevastopol, as well as the semi-occupied and occupied regions of four oblasts: Donetska, Khersonska, Luhanska, and Zaporizka, to ensure the accuracy of population estimates reported and its alignment with the survey sample coverage) defined in the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA)'s Common Operational Datasets on Population Statistics (COD-PS). All numbers are rounded for ease of use. Population estimates are rounded to the nearest 1,000. Data collection was facilitated by Multicultural Insights. Additional analysis is available upon request to dtmukraine@iom.int.

In this report, Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) are defined as individuals who have been forced to flee or to leave their homes, or who are staying outside their habitual residences in Ukraine due to the full-scale invasion in February 2022, regardless of whether they hold registered IDP status. The terms "return" and "returnee" are used without prejudice to status and refer to all people who have returned to their habitual residence after a period of displacement of a minimum of two weeks since February 2022, whether from abroad or from internal displacement within Ukraine. This definition excludes individuals who have come back to Ukraine from abroad but who have not returned to their places of habitual residence in the country and who are considered IDPs. Full definitions of population groups may be found in the [Methodological Note](#).

Limitations: Those currently residing outside the territory of Ukraine were not interviewed, following active exclusion. Population estimates assume that minors (those under 18 years old) are accompanied by their adult parents or guardians. The sample frame is limited to adults using mobile phones and who were in areas where phone networks were fully functional for the entire period of the survey. People residing in the Autonomous Republic of Crimea (ARC) or the occupied areas of Donetska, Zaporizka, Luhanska, and Khersonska Oblasts were not included in the survey. Estimates for Donetska, Zaporizka, and Khersonska Oblasts are underestimates as a result of coverage being limited to government-controlled areas and due to the limited number of respondents reached in occupied areas. For details on the methodology and sampling design, please refer to the full [Methodological Note](#).

²¹Estimates are underestimates due to coverage being limited to government-controlled areas, as well as the limited number of respondents reached in these areas.



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